

## 7. SUR KAHORI

**BY SHAH ABDUL LATIF BHITTAI**

1689 – 21 December 1752

Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai was a renowned Sufi poet, scholar, and saint from Sindh (now part of Pakistan). He is considered one of the greatest mystic poets of the Indo-Pakistan subcontinent. His most famous work, *Shah Jo Risalo*, is a collection of his poetic compositions, written in Sindhi, that blend Sufism, folklore, and spirituality. His poetry reflects themes of love, devotion, and the quest for divine union. Shah Latif's poems often focus on the love of the soul for God, expressing the universal longing for spiritual fulfillment. His teachings and poetry have left a profound impact on Sindhi culture and Sufism.



Oh mother! I saw the wandrers  
that a peep at the beloved had  
one night I in there place did stay  
there company to keep

to know them is in drowning deep  
to have a safety raft  
across far of realism through season past  
kahaoris have returned at last

there feet all are covered with dust and sand  
from what a distant foreign land  
they feed on roots and herbs wild grown  
and seek the land unseen unknown

on stony ground of dust and weed  
they lay their heads when rest they need  
to seek the light  
they do not cease

and they seek the light  
of the infinity

**EXERCISE 1- SUMMARY**

This melody is written by Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai. He gives attribution to those people who devote their lives for their beloved. They leave their materialistic world. They live austere life. They don't care about anything. Their only concern is to find their destination. For this whatever the hardships come they don't fall but are always courageous to seek the way of God. The poet has mentioned the character of Khahori as the pious the one who is in the search of truth. Khahori goes from place to places and faces many hardships to reach at his destination. They are not misled in fact they lit the fire where not any trace of birds is seen. The writer calls them the true seekers. They are only known to the people who have spiritual realms. Their faces are dry and they wore torn slippers. In the dream the Khahoris saw the people who had seen their beloved (Truth). He further experienced that we should have to spend night with such people who lived with God. The recognition of such people is like a boat in the ocean. They never experience restful sleep. They wander and totally absorbed in search and possess nothing except their steadfastness and determination. Khahoris usually spend their days and nights in the rocks, jungles and other unknown places where native people are hesitant to go. The purpose of spending the time at such places is to search for truth in order to make their God please with them. After his struggle a Khahori is rewarded with the in eternal truth, since he has been searching for it by roaming place to place. He saw his beloved and spent nights with God. All his efforts bore with fruit and he got what he wanted.

## EXERCISE 1- POST READING

**Q1. How is Kahori's character depicted by the poet?**

**Ans.** The question has been taken from the poem 'Sur Kahori', which means, 'The Melody of the seekers', written by the famous Sindhi sufi poet Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai. It has been taken from the collection of his poetry, called 'Shah Jo Risalo'.

The poet has mentioned the character of Kahori as the pious, the one who is in the search of truth. Kahoris go from place to place and face many hardships to reach their destination. They are not misled in fact they lit the fire where not any trace of birds is seen. The writer calls them the true seekers. They are only known to the people who have spiritual realms. Their faces are dry and they wear torn slippers.

**"Knock, And He'll open the door  
Vanish, And He'll make you shine like the sun  
Fall, And He'll raise you to the heavens  
Become nothing, And He'll turn you into everything."  
— Jalal Ad-Din Rumi —**

**Q2. How do the Kahoris experience sleep?**

**Ans.** In the dream the poet saw the people who had seen their beloved (Truth). He further experienced that we should have to spend night with such people who live with God. The recognition of such people is like a boat in the ocean. They never experience restful sleep. They wander, totally absorbed in search and possess nothing except their steadfastness and determination.

**Q3. Where and why do Kahoris spend their days and nights?**

**Ans.** Kahoris usually spend their days and nights in the rocks, jungles and other unknown places where native people are hesitant to go. The purpose of spending the time at such places is to search for truth in order to attain spiritual gratification and to please God.

**"The only way you're going to reach places you've never gone is if you trust God's  
direction to do things you've never done."  
— Germany Kent —**

**Q4. What does the poet want to say when he says "Where not a trace of birds is seen, fire is lit?"**

**Ans.** Sur Kahori's central theme is the human search for the divine and spiritual connection. Kahoris go from place to place and face many hardships to reach their destination. They are not misled, in fact they lit the fire where not a trace of birds is seen. The writer calls them the true seekers. This creates a stark image of an empty, lifeless place. Birds often symbolize life, freedom, and the soul. Their absence reinforces the sense of desolation. However, Kahori's presence serves as a source of life and vitality in an otherwise barren environment.

**"The world is saltwater. The more you drink, the thirstier you get"  
— Atef Ashab Uddin Sahil —**

**Q5. What reward does a Kahori get after his hard work?**

**Ans.** Sur Kahori's central theme is the human search for the divine and spiritual connection. After his struggle, a Kahori is rewarded with the eternal truth as he has been searching for it by roaming from place to place. He comes across the vision of his beloved and spends nights with God. All his efforts bore with fruit and he gets what he wanted. His

efforts are not in vain. Being resilient, consistent and determined, the Kahori gets what he desires.

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**Q6. Sur Khahori is a narration of a Kahori's struggle. Elaborate.**

**Ans.** Sur Khahori's central theme is the human search for the divine and spiritual connection. The poet has mentioned the character of Kahori as the pious, the one who is in search of truth. Kahori goes from place to place and faces many hardships to reach at his destination. They are not misled in fact they lit the fire where not any trace of birds is seen. The writer calls them the true seekers. They are only known to the people who have spiritual realms. Their faces are dry and they wear torn slippers. As a great writer once said that a free spirit is not bound by matter, materialism or opinion. They sing, dance and flow with the wind – for they are at one with it. They are nothing and everything – void and expanse. Even space and time does not confine or define them, for they are pure energy itself. This defines a Kahori and his life so well.

**“You give but little when you give of your possessions. It is when you give of yourself that you truly give.”  
— ‘Khalil Gibran’ —**

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— Jalal Ad-Din Rumi —**

**Q7. What is the central idea of the poem?**

**Ans.** Sur Khahori," translated as "Melody of Seekers," is a collection of Sindhi Sufi poetry, written by the renowned poet Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai in the 18th century. It forms a significant part of his larger work, "Shah Jo Risalo," a compilation of Sindhi poetry encompassing various themes and spiritual philosophies.

**‘There's no place too dark for God's light to penetrate and no heart too difficult to be set aflame by His love.’  
— (Anonymous) —**

This melody is written by Shah Abdul Latif Bhittai. He gives attribution to those people who devote their lives for their beloved. They leave their materialistic world. They live austere life. They don't care about anything. Their only concern is to find their destination. For this whatever the hardships come, they don't fall but are always courageous to seek the ways of God. When we come to an understanding of how much God loves us, we'll be able to truly trust Him no matter what circumstances come our way. The encounter with the spiritually awakened can spark a transformation within the seeker's own consciousness and help them see the world from a more enlightened perspective. Thus, to understand the love of God and His ways, we must understand and seek guidance from the ones who are the true seekers of His closeness and have thorough knowledge about the sources and ways to achieve the true Love of God.

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